

After the war, communists won power in China, causing nationalists to flee. The US presence in Japan lead to political change.

COMMUNISTS SEIZE POWER IN CHINA

During World War II, Chinese political factions had united against the Japanese, but open civil war reignited in 1946. In 1949, the **communist People's Liberation Army** won emphatic victories against forces of the Guomindang Nationalist Party at Huai-Hai and Nanjing, forcing the nationalists to retreat. **Mao Zedong**, leader of the Chinese Communist Party, declared the **People's Republic of China 424–25 >>**.

CHINESE REGIME IN TAIWAN

After his defeat, the nationalist leader **Chiang Kai-shek** fled China with 600,000 troops and two million refugees. Chiang refused to acknowledge Mao's government and established his alternative government in Taipei on the former Japanese colony of Taiwan.

US OCCUPATION OF JAPAN

Japan was occupied by the Allies until 1952. Its war machine was destroyed and war-crimes trials held. In 1947, a new constitution introduced universal suffrage (the right to vote) and banned Japan from having an army. In the 1950s, a memorial park was built in the center of Hiroshima in remembrance of the nuclear attack.



HIROSHIMA PEACE PARK

US GENERAL (1880–1964)

GENERAL MACARTHUR

US General Douglas MacArthur was the Supreme Allied Commander in the Pacific. He was born into a military family and began his distinguished military career in World War I. He rose to the rank of Army Chief of Staff in the interwar years. At the end of World War II he became Supreme Allied Commander in Japan and oversaw the drafting of a new Japanese constitution. In 1950–51 he led UN forces in Korea (see pp.406–07).



territories, including Indonesia and Burma, in return for guaranteed loyalty to Japan. The Japanese were often guilty of barbarism. Atrocities were committed against Chinese citizens and in Japan's notorious prison camps, where medical experiments were conducted on prisoners of war.

Turning points

The Japanese advance was checked in May 1942 when a naval force heading for southern New Guinea was defeated in the Coral Sea. A far more significant defeat came at the Battle of Midway in early June. The Japanese Admiral Yamomoto assembled a powerful force of aircraft carriers, battleships, submarines, and destroyers with the intention of surprising the US fleet at the American-held Midway Islands. However, US intelligence had cracked the Japanese code and the US Navy was well-prepared for their arrival. In the ensuing battle, Japan lost its main fleet of aircraft carriers and hundreds of pilots.

The Allied counteroffensive

As was the case in Europe, the tide of war in the Pacific turned in favor of the Allied Powers during 1943. This change was in many ways due to the

extraordinary military and industrial resources of the US. Once the US war effort was mobilized, Japan began to struggle to match its enemies, and Allied troops began to recapture occupied territories. In early 1945, British troops invaded Burma, under Admiral Lord Louis Mountbatten and Field Marshal Sir William Slim, liberating the country in May.

During 1944 and 1945, US power at sea and in the air began to have a decisive effect. A sea blockade of Japan cut off all imports, strangling the Japanese war economy. Another decisive US naval victory at the Battle of Leyte Gulf in October 1944 opened the way for America to regain the Philippines. In February 1945 the US invaded the island of Iwo Jima, gaining a base for fighter escorts to support

Pearl Harbor

Japan carried out a surprise bombing raid on the American fleet at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, on December 7, 1941. Thousands of American lives were lost, as well as many battleships, as seen engulfed in flames above.

US bombing raids on mainland Japan. Around 80,000 people died in the US fire-bombing of Tokyo. Victory in the Pacific was in sight for the Allies, but still Japan refused to surrender.

On August 6, 1945, the Allies dropped an atomic bomb on the Japanese city of Hiroshima (see p.405), and three days later on the city of Nagasaki. As news of the devastation sank in, the Soviet Union broke a neutrality pact with Japan by declaring war and invading Japanese-occupied Manchuria. These events persuaded the Japanese to sign an unconditional surrender on September 2, 1945.



Kamikaze

A Japanese volunteer *kamikaze* pilot flies his explosive-laden plane into a US battleship. Japan introduced this desperate tactic in 1944. By the end of the war, over 2,000 such suicide attacks had been launched.